

## Chapter 11

# Curriculum

## Meaning and Definition of Curriculum

Curriculum is the sum total of the school's efforts to influence learning whether in the class-room, on the playground or out of school. In fact curriculum has been described as, "the environment in motion." It includes "the totality of experiences that a pupil receives through the manifold activities that go on in the school—in the classroom, library, laboratory, workshop, playgrounds and in the numerous informal contacts between teachers and pupils. In this case, the whole life of the school becomes the curriculum which can touch the life of the students at all points and help in the of evaluation balanced personality. Curriculum is considered as a tool in the hands of the artist (the teacher) to mould his material (the pupils) in accordance with his ideal in his studio (the school)." The curriculum is an aid in the process of adjusting the child to the environment in which he functions from day to day and in wider environment in which he will have to organise his activities later.

## Definition of Curriculum

According to the American Association of School Administrators (1953) "In recent years the curriculum has been most commonly defined as all of the directed learning experiences of children and youth under the influence of the school."

Blond's Encyclopedia of Education (1966) defines "curriculum as all the experiences which a pupil has under the guidance of the school."

J Francis Brown (1984) states, "curriculum is all the learning which is planned and guided by the school."

Derek Rowntree in *Dictionary of Education* (1981) notes, "curriculum can refer to the total structure of ideas and activities developed by an educational institution to meet the learning needs of students and to achieve desired educational aims."

Education Commission 1964-66 has conceived the school curriculum "as the total of learning experience that the school provides for the pupils through all the manifold activities in the school and outside, that are carried on under its supervision. From this point of view, the distinction between curricular and extra-curricular work ceases to exist, and a school camp and games and sports are curricular or rather co-curricular activities."

Good's Dictionary of Education considers curriculum as "a body of prescribed educative experiences under school supervision, designed to provide an individual with the best possible training and experience to fit him for the society of which he is a part or to qualify him for a trade or profession."

J.P. Hills in *Dictionary of Education* (1982) writes, "A simple way of considering the curriculum in to see it in terms of four bases: content, methods, purposes, evaluation."

C.K. Nolan and W. Cook Watter in *Encyclopedia of Educational Research* (1960) regards curriculum as "all the educational experiences that a learner has under the guidance of a teacher."

Etymologically the term 'curriculum' is derived from the Latin word 'currere' which means 'run'. Thus Curriculum means 'a course' to be run for reaching a goal.

From above, the concept of curriculum may be explained

1. A curriculum includes all the subjects activities and experiences for the development of the child.
2. All these subjects, activities and experiences are under the guidance and supervision of teachers.
3. All these subjects, activities and experiences are offered in the school inside the classroom, in the farm, the laboratory in the workshop, in the playground etc.

4. Some portion of the curriculum is for all pupils while other portions may be in accordance with individual needs.
5. A diversified curriculum is provided in Class XI in the 10 + 2 pattern of education.

#### National Goals

- Curriculum and modernisation of society*—The modernisation of a society is tied up with the contents of the curriculum. Broadly speaking this implies in terms of curriculum objectives:
1. The development of a scientific outlook from early childhood.
  2. Loosening of bonds of dogmatism and dispelling of superstition, fatalism, dogmatism and passive resignation.
  3. Promoting the capacity to think rationally to enquire and judge for himself and to contribute to the stock of human knowledge.
  4. The development of productive capacity.
  5. The development a synthesising attitude towards science and culture.
  6. Development of values of a secular, socialist and a democratic state.
  7. Development of values of emotional integration and national unity.

#### Philosophical, Psychological and Sociological Basis of Curriculum Construction

Neither philosophy nor sociology nor psychology can on its own justify a curriculum to be used as the sole basis for curriculum planning. Illustration 11.1 though oversimplified illustrates the complexity of the task:

*Patterns of curriculum organisation*—Following are some of the important patterns of curriculum organisation:

1. Subject-centred pattern of curriculum.
2. Student centred pattern of curriculum.
3. Activity centred pattern of curriculum.
4. Experience centred pattern of curriculum.
5. Work centred pattern of curriculum.
6. Correlated pattern of curriculum.
7. Integrated pattern of curriculum.
8. Core pattern of curriculum.

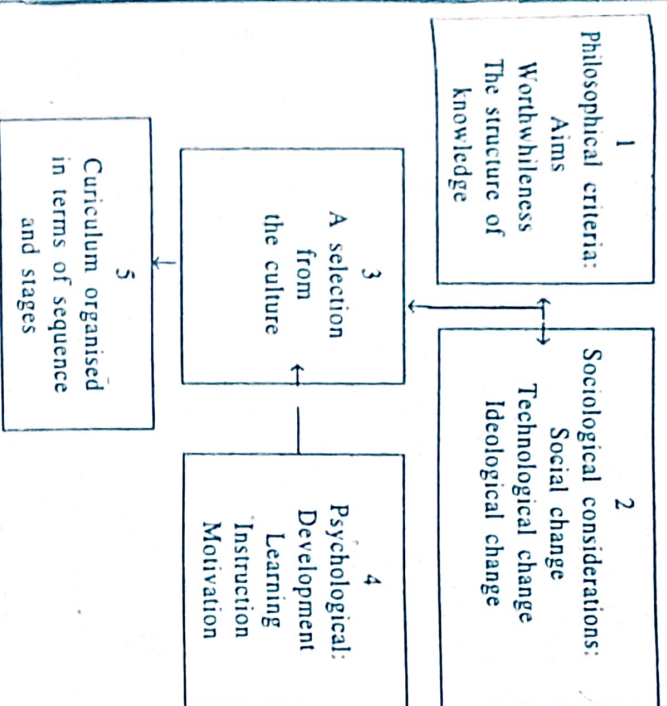


Illustration 11.1 Showing Curriculum Planning

#### Flexible and Student's Needs Centred Curriculum

The student-centred curriculum considers the student a 'hero' in the drama of education and places more emphasis on the student rather than the subjects. It should be in accordance with the three A's—Age, Ability and Aptitude of the student.

The following are the important characteristics of a child-centred curriculum:

1. The interests of the pupils facilitate their learning. Most of the young pupil's interests are socially derived; hence it makes the programme more life-related.
2. In terms of the highly developed Indian social organisation, co-operation is important. Therefore finding common interests and working together in terms of a unifying element bring about growth in life-related skills.

3. A very flexible school curriculum is needed. In these rapidly changing times, and the different backgrounds of pupils, too much structuring of courses and syllabi has resulted in the student's lack of real participation in the learning process. Hence many unstructured, free and flexible areas of learning according to the pupils' interests and individual needs, are essential.
4. Flexibility can be brought about not only in the content and areas of learning, but also in the use of instructional materials. The text-book has dominated the class room for too long. There must be multiple and varied resources suitable for pupils with different interests, abilities and stages of growth—reference books, news-papers, journals, excursions to museums, libraries, films, audio-tapes, television and others.
5. To teach in a class-room characterised by the student-centred approach requires that teachers must know a great deal about the growth and development of children and youth.

#### *Issues Involved in Curriculum Construction and Implementation*

1. *Why to formulate the curriculum*—This includes taking into consideration the aims of education. The educator, the teacher and the learner must be clear about the aims of education so that right efforts are made.
2. *For whom to formulate the curriculum*—The curriculum is to be formulated for the learner. It is, therefore very important that the curriculum shall be formulated according to the needs of the students, their individual differences, ages and stages.
3. *What to include in the curriculum*—This leads to the contents of the curriculum and the curriculum is described as the environment in motion. In a broader sense it includes various subjects, activities and experiences.
4. *Where to use the curriculum*—The curriculum is used in and outside the school—in the classroom, library, laboratory, workshop, playgrounds and in the numerous informal contacts between teachers and pupils etc.
5. *When to use the curriculum*—This is concerned with the different stages of the child so that 'motivational aspects' may be handled satisfactorily.

6. *How to use the curriculum*—This involves the knowledge and techniques of various methods of teaching—learning for making the teaching—learning process dynamic, effective and inspirational.
7. *Who is to use the curriculum*—The teacher and the students are the main consumers. The teachers must understand themselves also.
8. *Who is to formulate the curriculum*—The formation of curriculum is a joint enterprise in which teachers should play a dominant role. The views of the learners should also be given their due importance.
9. *What type of resources to be used in the curriculum*—With the rapid advances in science and technology new learning resources are coming into use. A judicious use of the traditional and modern audio-visual aids should be made.
10. *How to evaluate the outcomes of the curriculum implementation*—This is concerned with the success of the learners as well as of the teachers. Outcomes are evaluated by a number of tests.
11. *How to bring about the required changes in the curriculum*—Curriculum must be evaluated from time to time so as to make it conform with the changing needs.

#### *Principles of Curriculum Construction*

1. Conservation of Culture.
2. Principle of future-orientation.
3. Principle of creativity.
4. Principle of activity.
5. Principle of preparation for life.
6. Principle of child-centred education.
7. Principle of maturity.
8. Principle of individual differences.
9. Principle of horizontal and vertical articulation.
10. Principle of linking with life.
11. Principle of balances of activities and subjects.
12. Principle of flexibility.
13. Principle of leisure.

14. Principle of productivity.
15. Principle of nationalism.
16. Principle of democracy.
17. Principle of socialism.
18. Principle of secularism.
19. Principle of internationalism.

### *Teachers Participation in Curriculum Planning*

Recognition of the fact that no real progress can take place without the teacher's involvement in curriculum development came only a few decades ago even in the advanced countries of the west and that too after numerous failures in curriculum revision. Prior to that curriculum revision was done in much the same way as it has been done in India. The decision about the overall purpose of schools and universities, the general scope and structures of their programmes was taken by public men, experts and administrators without the benefit of any real participation by teachers. Today, planning and action by teachers are promoted in these countries. Individual and cooperative efforts by teachers to decide when, how and what to teach, to revise courses, select content, plan units and produce teaching aids has become a common practice. The reliance on text-books and prescribed courses of study has diminished.

Several curriculum development studies have clearly shown that a significant improvement has taken place where the participation of teachers was both more extensive and more inclusive and where more teachers were involved in decision-making and in the production of materials. This led Krug to conclude in 1957 that "teacher participation in curriculum planning today is to be regarded not as a pleasant gesture to the teachers, but rather as an indispensable part of the process."

Theoretically speaking teachers may be called curriculum makers but seldom has the business of curriculum making in India secured the wide-spread participation of the general body of teachers. In spite of all the lip service to the teachers key role in improving instruction, their participation in curriculum planning and preparation of content and teaching materials has so far received very little practical recognition. Indian teachers have been merely, "implementing to their best of abilities and resources

the curriculum and syllabi prepared by outsiders and prescribed by the State Directorate of Education. In actual practice the 'textbook' has become synonymous with the 'curriculum' in so far as the actual implementation of the curriculum is concerned."

Sometimes representatives of teachers are associated in the development of the curriculum at the national and state levels. The NCERT and State Councils of Educational Research and Training organise various courses for teachers to provide opportunities for participation in curriculum development and implementation.

### *Curriculum and Syllabus*

A UNESCO publication entitled "Preparing Textbook Manuscripts" (1970) has differentiated between the curriculum and syllabus: "The curriculum sets out the subjects to be studied, their order and sequence and so ensures some balance between humanities and science and consistency in the study of subjects, thus facilitating inter-subject links. It follows that the curriculum determines the amount of school-times allotted to each subject, the aim of teaching each subject, the place of the motor skills which take time to acquire and, possibly, the variations between rural and urban school teaching. The curriculum in the schools of developing countries is often directly related to the requirements for developments. The syllabus determines the basic content of instructions in a given subject and the range of knowledge and skills which the pupils must acquire and establish in detail the themes and individual points to be studied in each school year... the syllabus is a refined detail of the curriculum at a particular stage of learning for a particular subject."